

Share your Windows

Find out how you can share your Windows XP system with others and give them the right privileges

In small offices, colleagues may often be required to share computers. This compromises your privacy, making your PC vulnerable to prying eyes. Early versions of Windows, such as Windows 95, did not provide any sort of privacy between the different users of the system. A system's security does not depend solely on the software used; It also depends on the file system. The popular file system FAT32, does not provide any form of security at the lower level. To overcome this limitation, Microsoft developed the NTFS file system that has advanced features to allow it to define exactly what actions each user can perform.

Not so simple file-sharing

Windows XP comes with two file-sharing features—simple file-sharing and shared documents. The former allows you to decide the level at which other users can access shared documents over the network. Simple file sharing is enabled by default. Now to share a folder, right-click on it, select Sharing and Security, and

enable the 'Share this folder on the network' option. Give it a sharename that can be used by everyone to access it with equal rights. All users over the network will be able to view the contents of the shared folder, and its sub-folders—they will not have access to any other folder. Give write-access to the shared folder by enabling the 'Allow network users to change my files' option.

To share documents using the latter method, drag the files and folders that you want to share into the Shared Documents folder. The contents of this folder will be visible to all the users who log into the machine locally. The shared documents can be accessed locally through the My Computer window. The contents of the My Documents folder are only visible to the administrators of the system, and the respective users. If you need to secure some folders in the My Documents folder from all the users, including the administrators, then right-click the folder, select 'Sharing and

Security' and then select the 'Make this folder private' option. Remember that this will work only for the sub-folders in the My Documents folder.

Sharing securely

These are many simple ways of sharing data, but this may not be helpful if you wish to, say, share the company balance sheet with just your boss and the company's financial consultant. Such specific requirements can be achieved using Windows XP, but you have to turn off the simple file sharing feature. Doing this allows you to configure a whole new set of options. Assume that you have to configure the system for two sets of people with different functions—designers and accountants. Each group should be authorised to run a set of applications,